README

Extract Pages — User Guide

Extract Pages is an Adobe InDesign script that splits a document into separate InDesign (`.indd`) files. You can split by page range, by section, at each chapter heading (paragraph style), or by alternate layout. Each new file keeps the masters, styles, links and page numbering of the original. Text that flows across pages is cut cleanly at the page boundaries.

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1. The scripts

File	What it is
`ExtractInDesignPages.jsx`	**The main script.** In Paragraph Style mode you can select **several** paragraph styles (e.g. *Part* and *Chapter number*), and every one of them starts a new file. It also supports the `<h>` naming code.
`ExtractPages_Startup.jsx`	Optional. A startup script that adds **File › Extract Pages…** to InDesign's menu. It runs `ExtractInDesignPages.jsx`.

2. Installation

1. **Main script:** copy `ExtractInDesignPages.jsx` into InDesign's Scripts Panel folder, or into any subfolder of it:
   - macOS: `/Applications/Adobe InDesign 20xx/Scripts/Scripts Panel/`
   - Windows: `C:\Program Files\Adobe\Adobe InDesign 20xx\Scripts\Scripts Panel\`

   The script then appears in **Window › Utilities › Scripts**. Double-click it to run it.
2. **Optional menu command:** copy `ExtractPages_Startup.jsx` into `…/Adobe InDesign 20xx/Scripts/startup scripts/` and restart InDesign.
   - **File › Extract Pages…** appears just above **Package…**.
   - The command is greyed out when no document is open.
   - It finds `ExtractInDesignPages.jsxbin` or `ExtractInDesignPages.jsx` anywhere under the `Scripts` folder, and uses the `.jsxbin` file if both exist.

> Keep the main script in the **Scripts Panel** folder, not in *startup scripts*. If it is placed there by mistake, it detects that no document is open at startup and exits quietly.

Tested with InDesign 2025, 2026 and 2027.

3. Before you start

- **The document must be open and saved.** Files are cut from the saved file on disk.
    - A document that has never been saved (Untitled) gives the message *“Please save your document before running this script.”*
    - If the document has **unsaved changes**, the script asks: **“Save changes to”…” before extracting?“**, offering **Save** or **Cancel**. A converted document (for example, one from an older InDesign version) is saved with Save As.
- Your document is **never changed**, unless you choose **Remove Pages from Original after Extraction** (see Options).
- Check that you have enough free disk space. Each output file is a full InDesign document holding only its pages.

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4. Running the script

1. Open the document and run the script, either from the Scripts panel or from **File › Extract Pages…**.
2. If you are asked, save the document.
3. Set the options in the dialog and click **Extract**. Press **Return/Enter** to extract, or **Esc** to cancel.
    - A button only acts if you press **and release** the mouse on it. Sliding off the button before releasing cancels the click.
4. Choose a **destination folder**.
5. If the run will create **more than 50 files**, you are asked to confirm. A large run can take several minutes and cannot be cancelled once it starts.
6. A progress window shows each file as it is made.
7. A summary alert reports how many files were saved, where they were saved, and any problems.

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5. The dialog, option by option

The heading at the top shows the page count and the first and last page labels, e.g. **317 pages (i–302)**.

5.1 Extract By

Choose **one** of the following methods.

All Pages

Extracts the whole document, split according to **Split Into**:

Split Into	Result
One File per Page *(default)*	Every page becomes its own file.
One File per Spread	Each spread (for example a facing left/right pair) becomes one file.

Page Range

Type the pages to extract in the text field. Clicking in the field selects this option.

Range syntax

You type	Meaning
`15-20`	Pages 15 to 20
`15-20, 30-34`	**2 files**: 15–20, and 30–34. Commas separate files.
`15-20, 22-25; 30-34`	**2 files**: (15–20 + 22–25), and 30–34. When a semicolon is present, **semicolons separate files and commas join ranges into one file.**
`7`	Page 7 only
`6-`	Page 6 to the end of the document
`-11`	The start of the document to page 11
`iv-xii`, `A-3`	Page **labels** as shown in the Pages panel (roman numerals, section prefixes, etc.)
`+6-`	The **6th page in the document** to the end. A `+` means absolute position, so `+1` is always the first page whatever its label.
`+1-+10`	The first ten pages by position

Numbers without `+` match the page **labels** you see in the Pages panel. If the document restarts numbering (for example i–xiv, then 1–302), use labels or `+` positions to refer to the page you mean.

If the entry can't be read, you get *"The page range could not be interpreted. Please check your entry."*

Split Into (Page Range)

Split Into	Result
One File per Group (, / ;) *(default)*	One file per group, as described in the syntax table above.
One File per Page	Every page in the range becomes its own file.
One File per Spread	Every spread in the range becomes its own file.

Section

Creates **one file per document section** (the sections defined with **Numbering & Section Options**). This option is only available when the document has more than one section.

Paragraph Style

Starts a **new file at every page that holds a paragraph in the selected style(s)**. Use your chapter-opening style, such as *Chapter number*, *Chapter Title* or *Part*.

- Choose the style(s) from the list. You can select several: use ⌘**-click** (Mac) or **Ctrl-click** (Windows) to select more than one.
  - Any selected style starts a new file. For example, select **Part** *and* **Chapter number** so that both part openers and chapter openers begin new files.
  - Your selection is **remembered** for next time. If none of the remembered styles exist in the current document, the first style in the list is selected.
- Styles inside style groups are listed with their group path. *[Basic Paragraph]* is not listed.
- **Pages before the first heading** (title page, copyright, contents and other front matter) become a separate **front-matter file**.

- If **several headings fall on the same page** (e.g. a *Part* heading and a *Chapter number* on one page), that page starts **one** file. The file is named after the first heading in reading order.
- A heading that is placed on the pasteboard (not on a page) is ignored.

Alternate Layout

Creates **one file per alternate layout** (e.g. *iPad H* and *iPad V*). This option is only available when the document has more than one layout.

5.2 Options

Keep Original Page Numbers *(on by default)*

- **On:** every file keeps the page labels it had in the original document, including the numbering style, section prefix and starting number. A file cut from pages XII–XX still starts at XII, and a chapter starting on page 145 still starts at 145. Running heads, folios and cross-references to page numbers stay correct.
- **Off:** every file is renumbered **1, 2, 3…** in plain Arabic numerals.

Remove Pages from Original after Extraction *(Page Range only)*

After the files are made, the extracted pages are **deleted from your original document**.

- Text threaded through the removed pages is removed with them. The text on the remaining pages stays in place, with the same line breaks.
- Endnotes that belong to the removed pages are removed. Endnote pages still needed by the remaining pages are kept, and empty trailing endnote pages are dropped.
- Pages are removed **only if every file was saved.** If any file fails, the original is left untouched and the final message says so.
- The removal is a **single undo step**: **Edit › Undo Remove Extracted Pages** restores all the pages.

- The original is **left open with the changes unsaved.** Check it, then save it, undo the removal, or use **File › Revert** if you change your mind.

> ⚠️ This is destructive. Keep a backup of the document.

5.3 File Names

Automatic *(default)*

The document name, an underscore, and then a label:

Mode	Example file name
All Pages / Page Range, single page	`Alice_64.indd`
All Pages / Page Range, several pages	`RSE_24-28.indd` (first to last page label)
Section	`Book_Pages_i-xiv.indd`, `Book_Pages_1-36.indd`
Paragraph Style	`Treasure Island_Sons of Fury.indd` (heading text, up to 50 characters)
Paragraph Style, front matter	`Treasure Island_i-x.indd` (page range)
Alternate Layout	`Brochure_iPad V.indd`

Custom

Builds each name from a **template** that you type, using the codes in the next section. Clicking in the field selects **Custom**. Hover over the field to see a tooltip that lists every code.

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6. Custom file-name codes (reference)

Code	Replaced by	Example result
`<fn>`	The document's name, without `.indd`	`Treasure Island`
`<fp>`	**Label** of the file's first page, as shown in the Pages panel	`VI`, `12`, `A-3`
`<lp>`	**Label** of the file's last page	`xiv`

Code	Replaced by	Example result
`<+fp>`	**Position** of the first page in the original document (1st page = 1)	`6`
`<+lp>`	**Position** of the last page	`20`
`#`	Counter: 1, 2, 3… in output order	`1`
`##`, `###` …	Zero-padded counter	`01`, `001`
`[text]`	The bracketed text appears **only when the file has more than one page**. The brackets themselves are removed.	`Page[s]` gives `Page` or `Pages`
`<sm>`	The **section marker** of the file's first page (Numbering & Section Options › Section Marker)	`Chapter 3`
`<alt>`	Name of the file's **alternate layout**	`iPad V`
`<p:Style Name>`	Text of the **first paragraph in that style** within the file (up to 80 characters). For a style in a group, use the name or the full path as listed.	`<p:Chapter Title>` gives `The Old Sea-dog`
`<p:…>` with several styles	**Fallback:** the text from the first of the listed styles that occurs in the file. See Style fallback below.	`3`
`<h>`	*(Paragraph Style mode only)* the **heading that started the file**, from whichever selected style started it	`Part One`

Example: the 6th page of a document is labelled *VI*. For that page, `<fp>` gives `VI` and `<+fp>` gives `6`.

Style fallback

List two or more style names inside one `<p:…>` code, separated by a vertical bar (`|`). The code uses the first listed style that occurs in the file. This is useful when chapters use one style *or* the other:

```
<p:Chapter number|Chapter number no break>
```

Styles are tried in the order written. If none of them occurs in the file, the code drops out. A style whose own name contains `|` still works when written in full.

Rules that apply to every name

- **Codes that find nothing disappear,** together with the extra spaces around them. For example, `<sm>` with no section marker, or `<p:Part>` in a file that has no Part heading, simply drops out without leaving a double space.
- Characters that aren't allowed in file names (`/ \ : * ? " < > |`) are replaced by spaces.
- Names are limited to **120 characters**.
- If the template produces an **empty name**, the automatic name is used instead.
- **Names never overwrite existing files.** If a name is already used in this run or already exists in the folder, `1`, `2`, … is added, e.g. `Chapter-1.indd`. If another file appears at a chosen path while the script is running, that file is skipped, reported, and left untouched.
- `<h>` and the `<p:…>` codes are left blank for the front-matter file if it holds no such paragraph.

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7. Recipes and examples

Goal	Template	Sample result
Book name and page range, with a singular/plural word	`<fn> - Page[s] <fp>[ through <lp>]`	`Treasure Island - Pages 15 through 28` · `Treasure Island - Page 7`
Heading of each chapter	`Rebel Sultans - <h> - Page[s] <fp>[ through <lp>]`	`Rebel Sultans - The Sultanate of Delhi - Pages 24 through 41`
Numbered chapters	`## <h>`	`01 Prologue`, `02 The Old Sea-dog` …
Section files named by section marker	`<fn> <sm>`	`Manual Appendix A`
One file per page, by position	`<fn> p<+fp>`	`Alice p1`, `Alice p2` …

Goal	Template	Sample result
Alternate layouts	`<fn> (<alt>)`	`Brochure (iPad H)`

Recipes using style fallbacks

These examples are for a book like *Treasure Island*, where a chapter uses either *Chapter number* or *Chapter number no break*, and some chapters also have a *Part* heading.

Chapter number from whichever style the chapter uses

```
Treasure Island <p:Chapter number|Chapter number no break> Page[s] <fp>[ through <lp>]
```

Result: `Treasure Island 3 Pages 21 through 30`

Part title if present, otherwise the chapter number

```
Treasure Island <p:Part|Chapter number|Chapter number no break> Page[s] <fp>[ through <lp
>]
```

Results: `Treasure Island Part One Pages 1 through 12` · `Treasure Island 4 Pages 31 through 40`

Part title and chapter number (the Part is omitted when absent)

```
Treasure Island <p:Part> <p:Chapter number|Chapter number no break> Page[s] <fp>[ through
<lp>]
```

Results: `Treasure Island Part One 1 Pages 1 through 12` · `Treasure Island 2 Pages 13 through 20`

How `<h>` and `<p:…>` differ:

- `<h>` is the heading that started the file. It comes from the styles you **selected in the dialog**, and works in Paragraph Style mode only.
- `<p:Style>` looks inside the file for **any** style you name, whether or not it was used to split the document. It works in every mode.

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8. What is preserved in each file

- **Page content and layout:** all page items, layers, styles, swatches, and document settings.
- **Parent pages:** each file keeps only the parent pages its own pages use, plus any parents those are based on. Overrides of parent items are kept. Unused parents are removed. If every page is set to [None], one parent remains, because InDesign requires a document to have at least one.
- **Links:** linked images stay linked. Embedded content stays embedded.
- **Spreads:** facing-page spreads keep their left/right arrangement. Items that span a spread are kept. Pages are not shuffled while other pages are removed.
- **Page numbering:** see *Keep Original Page Numbers*. Section markers are kept.
- **Threaded text:** a story that flows through the whole book is cut at the file's first and last page.
    - Each file starts with the text that was at the top of its first page, and ends with the text at the bottom of its last page.
    - **Line and page breaks stay exactly as in the original.** The text that follows the last page is held hidden on the pasteboard so that the final page does not re-flow.
    - Frames that are threaded within one file stay threaded: two linked frames on the same page (or, when splitting by spread, on the same spread) remain one story. They are not cut, and they do not create overset text.
- **Footnotes** travel with their reference text.
- **Endnotes:**
    - *Document-wide endnotes:* each file contains the endnotes referenced on its pages. They are placed on endnote pages after the extracted pages, and unused endnote pages are trimmed.
    - *Per-chapter (Story-scope) endnotes:* each chapter keeps its own endnote section.

- **Small file size:** every file is written with a full Save As, so it contains only its own pages. It doesn't carry a hidden copy of the original document.
- **Previews:** if previews are switched on in your Preferences, files are saved with InDesign's default preview (first 2 pages, Large 512 × 512), or with your own setting if it is smaller (e.g. first page only, or Medium). Your preview preferences are restored afterwards.
- **Open Recent:** only the finished files appear in **File › Open Recent**. No temporary files are listed.
- When you open an extracted file, it shows its **first page**.

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9. Progress, results and problem messages

- **Progress window:** shows *"Extracting 3 of 14:"* and the file name, which wraps over several lines if it is long, plus a progress bar. For large documents it first shows *"Getting files x–y of N ready..."* while temporary parts are prepared (see Performance).
- **Finish:** *"Extraction complete. N files saved to: "*.
- **Problems:** listed under the summary if anything needs attention. The usual one is an **overset-text warning** for a file. It typically means a table, or a paragraph set to *Keep Lines Together*, runs past the file's last page and cannot be split there. Open that file and check its last page.
- Messages before the run:

Message	Cause
Please open a document before running Extract Pages.	No document is open.
Please save your document before running this script.	The document has never been saved.
Please enter a page range...	Page Range is selected but the field is empty.
Please choose at least one paragraph style.	Paragraph Style is selected, but no style is selected.

Message	Cause
Please enter a custom file-name template, or choose Automatic.	Custom is selected but the template is empty.
The page range could not be interpreted.	The range syntax is wrong, or the pages don’t exist.
Nothing to extract for the chosen option.	For example, the selected style doesn’t occur in the document.

10. Performance

- Time depends mainly on the **number of page items** (frames, graphics, line-number frames) and on the length of threaded stories, not just on the page count.
- **Large documents (1,000+ page items)** are first split into temporary parts of about 40 pages, so each file is cut from a small part instead of from the whole book. This is much faster. The temporary parts are deleted automatically.
- Documents with **thousands of small frames** (for example a line-number frame beside every line) take noticeably longer to process. Their very first save can also take a few minutes.
- Screen redraw is switched off during the run, and **Smart Text Reflow** is paused temporarily so that InDesign doesn’t add or remove pages. Your settings, including the fields of the **Find/Change** dialog, are restored afterwards.
- A run **cannot be cancelled** once it has started. Test with a short page range first if you are unsure.

11. Limitations

- **Tables, and paragraphs set to “Keep Lines Together”, can’t be split across two files.** If one runs past a file’s last page, that file reports overset text.
- **Partial chapters with endnotes:** when you extract only part of a chapter, its endnotes are renumbered from 1 in the new file. Because the numbers may be shorter or longer, lines that contain endnote references can re-break slightly.

- **Endnote-only pages:** an extract that consists only of endnote pages, without the pages that reference those notes, comes out with those pages empty.
- **Remove Pages from Original** is only available for Page Range extractions.
- **Headings on the pasteboard** are ignored by Paragraph Style mode.
- Interactive and cross-document features (hyperlinks or cross-references to pages that are not in the file, book-level numbering) refer only to what exists in each extracted file.

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12. Troubleshooting and FAQ

Running from File › Extract Pages… behaves differently from the Scripts panel.
Use the supplied `ExtractPages_Startup.jsx`. A script run directly from inside a menu command can't fully close documents until the command finishes, which causes errors such as *"Cannot save … because it is already open"*. The supplied launcher avoids this by handing the run back to InDesign, so it runs exactly as it does from the Scripts panel. On Windows it falls back to running the script directly.

An "Untitled" document flashes or appears during the run.
This was fixed. The working copy is now prepared without a window, and your document stays in front. If you still see it, make sure you have installed the current script version.

Extracted files are larger than expected.
Each file is a full InDesign document, so it includes all fonts, styles, swatches and master pages, even for a few pages. Very large output files usually mean high-resolution **embedded** images. Linked images don't add to the file size.

The files' page numbers are wrong.
Check **Keep Original Page Numbers**. When it is on, labels match the original. When it is off, every file starts at 1.

My chapters use different styles for the chapter number.
Select all of those styles in the Paragraph Style list. For file names, use `<h>`, or use a fallback such as `<p:Chapter number|Chapter number no break>`.

Some file names end in "-1", "-2".
Another file with the same name already existed in the destination folder, or two

files in this run produced the same name. Add `#` or `<fp>` to your template to keep names unique.

InDesign seems to stop responding.
For large or line-numbered documents, the first save and the staging step can take several minutes. Watch the progress window. It updates between steps.

Script creator: Ravi Kiran. Copyright © 2026 Ravi Kiran. All rights reserved.